

Apple AirPods Pro (2nd generation)

One for many, but not all

When Apple launched their AirPods Pro (2nd generation), the hype was real. As you might have seen in our Digit Zero1 Awards article for the Best Premium Truly Wireless Earphones, the AirPods Pro (2nd generation) were bested only by the Samsung Galaxy Buds 2 Pro (The Winner), and the Sony WF-1000XM4. Both the Sonys and the Samsung TWS earbuds are arguably more universally compatible and were evenly matched with Apple for the most part in terms of pure performance. But there's a lot more to a product than just performance, right? So, to take a deeper look into the AirPods Pro (2nd generation), we put them through our extensive testing process.

BUILD AND DESIGN

One look at the AirPods Pro (2nd generation), and you will be able to make out that they are a pair of AirPods straight from the house of Apple. The simple white capsule design, which is extremely pocketable and easy to use, with the metallic hinge.

The buds themselves also carry over the aesthetics of the last gen AirPods Pro with subtle design changes. As for the materials, both the case and the buds are built using the same shiny but durable glossy plastic, with the lanyard loop, the hinge, and the bottom of the case with the speaker and the lightning ports getting a metallic treatment.

FEATURES

The Apple AirPods Pro (2nd generation) received a few new software features as well. The first and most impressive one for us was the speaker that Apple added to the case to help you find it in case it has been misplaced. Next was the mapped spatial audio. With the latest AirPods, Apple introduced personalised spatial audio, which uses the camera of your phone to map your ears, tuning the spatial audio accordingly. While in day-to-day use, you might not feel the



difference, but it is there. The mapping does fill up some of the blank spots that would have otherwise been there in your listening experience. However, keep in mind that as soon as you move away from an Apple device and decide to pair the AirPods with a non-Apple device, you will lose a lot of functionality.

PERFORMANCE

The AirPods Pro (2nd generation) come packed with a new H2 chip and a custom high-excursion Apple driver along with a custom high dynamic range amplifier. Thanks to these drivers, the overall sound signature of the AirPods Pro leaned towards the warmer side. This means that most genres of music that you listen to will be reproduced well. But, in some tracks, owing to the boosted lower mids, the sound would seem a little boomy. This might be something that most people would not even notice. And, given the way Spatial Audio works, you will not even realise that the sound signature is a bit off in some cases.

Overall, the mids and highs are reproduced in a way that would put many other earphones to shame. In our testing, we loved the way the AirPods handled vocal heavy tracks like Rescue Me and

metal tracks like Centuries. The only place where we felt the presence of boosted bass was in tracks like UpTown Funk.

As for the ANC, it worked like a charm. However, in certain situations, like in outdoor environments, it paled in comparison to the likes of the Sony WF-1000XM4. The microphone on the AirPods also fared well when we tested it in different environments. Even in fairly large rooms where there is a lot of echo, the AirPods handled themselves well. On the receiver's end, minimal echo was heard, and the caller's voice was clear and crisp.

BATTERY

The battery of the AirPods Pro (2nd generation), while we were testing them, lasted for about 5.5 hours with ANC off and volume set to 50 per cent. With ANC and Spatial Audio turned on, the battery life dropped to about 5 hours, which is pretty impressive. One issue that we noticed during our battery tests was that one of the earbuds drained the battery slightly faster than the other.

VERDICT

With the AirPods Pro (2nd generation), Apple has pushed their bar even higher. Several improvements over the last generation of AirPods Pro. The AirPods make for a great pair of premium TWS for users who are a part of the Apple Ecosystem. The limitations come into play as soon as you move out of the ecosystem, we'd hold back on recommending them to users working with a Windows PC or an Android smartphone. A few other TWS have a much better cross-platform performance and compatibility and provide a similar, if not better, feature set.

—Satvik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

Chip: Apple H2 headphone chip, Apple U1 chip | IP Rating: IPX4 | Weight: 5.3 grams | Connectivity: Bluetooth 5.3 | Sensors: Dual beamforming microphones, Inward-facing microphone, Skin-detect sensor, Motion-detecting accelerometer, Speech-detecting accelerometer | Audio Technology: Custom high-excursion Apple driver, Custom high dynamic range amplifier

CONTACT

Phone: Web form | Email: Web form | Website: www.apple.com/in

